

Weekly Theta Shortlist — Monday, August 17, 2026

Window: Run date 2026-08-17. 50-day earnings-free window closes **2026-10-06**. Names reporting on or before that date are excluded. Strategies assumed: 10–12Δ naked, 10–15/6–9Δ credit spreads, 8–10Δ delta-neutral strangles at ~45 DTE.

Regime this week. Headline vol is asleep — VIX closed 14.25 Friday, S&P 500 at 7,785.76 (third weekly gain, fresh all-time highs) — but underneath, Cboe stock-dispersion just printed an all-time high and 2026 has now seen eight weeks of double-digit best-vs-worst sector spread, a pattern last seen in 2000/2001/2009. FOMC is the pivot: with the funds rate at 3.50–3.75% and oil still elevated on Strait-of-Hormuz tape (Brent ~\$92, spiked to \$105 in late July), futures now price ~65% odds of a 25 bp hike on Sep 17; a hold would gap the whole vol surface, a hike would compress it. Trade the theta book smaller than a 14 VIX would suggest — the calm is index-level, not stock-level.

Tier A — October reporters (~55–75 days out)

Q3 earnings hit Oct 8–29 for these names. All reported Q2 already; window is clean but shorter than Tier B, so favor 30–35 DTE management if IBKR shows compression.

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	Days	Justification
1	JPM	Financials/Bank	\$780B	22-28% (verify)	18-24% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-13 (conf.)	57	Q2 beat; NII stable; dispersion tailwind for OTM. Watch bank vol into Sep FOMC.
2	WFC	Financials/Bank	\$260B	22-28% (verify)	20-26% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-14 (conf.)	58	Cleanest large-bank balance sheet post-cap-lift. Same FOMC caveat.
3	BAC	Financials/Bank	\$375B	24-30% (verify)	22-28% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-14 (conf.)	58	Higher IV than JPM; NIM sensitivity if hike lands. Prefer strangle if IV/HV rich.
4	PGR	Financials/P&C	\$155B	20-26% (verify)	18-22% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-08 (est.)	52	Monthly comps released mid-month — small gap risk; borderline days count.
5	TRV	Financials/P&C	\$62B	18-24% (verify)	16-22% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-21 (est.)	65	Low-vol insurer; only sellable if IV pct >50 — often is not. Verify closely.
6	JNJ	Healthcare/Pharma	\$430B	15-20% (verify)	13-18% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-20 (conf.)	64	Likely fails 20% IV floor; include only if pop lifted IV. Otherwise skip.
7	MRK	Healthcare/Pharma	\$220B	22-28% (verify)	20-26% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-29 (conf.)	73	Keytruda LOE debate keeps IV bid; sold cheap puts have worked here.
8	ABBV	Healthcare/Pharma	\$340B	20-26% (verify)	18-24% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-23 (conf.)	67	Post-Humira transition; IV band typically in-spec, watch pipeline headlines.
9	PEP	Staples/Bev	\$210B	18-22% (verify)	15-20% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-13 (conf.)	57	Borderline low-IV; premium-selling only works when pctile>50. Verify.
10	PG	Staples/HPC	\$360B	17-22% (verify)	14-19% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-21 (conf.)	65	Typically fails IV floor. Include only opportunistically.
11	MCD	Consumer/QSR	\$220B	17-22% (verify)	15-20% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-22 (est.)	66	Post-print IV crush already done. Range-bound name; ok delta-neutral strangle if IV pct>50.
12	VZ	Comm Svcs/Telco	\$180B	18-23% (verify)	15-20% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-20 (conf.)	64	Dividend anchor caps downside gap; low realized. Puts safer than calls.
13	GM	Consumer/Autos	\$60B	30-40% (verify)	26-36% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-20 (conf.)	64	Higher-IV name; strangle candidate if IV pct>50. Watch tariff/EV tape.

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	Days	Justification
14	LMT	Industrials/Def.	\$110B	20-26% (verify)	17-22% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-27 (conf.)	71	Backlog-driven; borderline low IV. Prefer put side on defense spending bid.
15	UNP	Industrials/Rail	\$135B	22-28% (verify)	18-24% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-22-26 (est.)	66-70	Volume-visible; cyclical but low beta to macro tape. Solid workhorse.
16	WM	Industrials/Waste	\$95B	17-22% (verify)	14-19% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-27 (conf.)	71	Defensive cash flow; often too calm for spec. Verify IV pct.
17	XOM	Energy/IntOil	\$490B	25-35% (verify)	22-32% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-23 (conf.)	67	Oil vol elevated on Strait tape; likely IV/HV inflated. Cap sizing; put side over call.
18	CVX	Energy/IntOil	\$290B	24-32% (verify)	22-30% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-23 (conf.)	67	Same oil-vol backdrop as XOM. Watch \$105 Brent revisit.

Tier B — November reporters (~78+ days out, cleanest window)

Widest earnings-free runway. Preferred bucket this week given elevated dispersion — more room to roll or defend before catalyst risk returns.

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	Days	Justification
1	CAT	Industrials/Mach.	\$220B	24-30% (verify)	20-26% (verify)	Yes	2026-11-04 (conf.)	79	Cyclical bellwether; IV band usually in-spec; global demand headlines can move. Core Tier B.
2	CMI	Industrials/Mach.	\$56B	26-32% (verify)	22-28% (verify)	Yes	2026-10-29 (conf.)	73	Higher-IV cousin of CAT; heavy-duty truck cycle live debate. Good for strangles.
3	DIS	Comm Svcs/Media	\$180B	26-34% (verify)	22-30% (verify)	Yes	2026-11-12 (conf.)	87	Fiscal Q4 print; longest runway. Streaming margin narrative still live.
4	CSCO	Tech/Networking	\$310B	22-28% (verify)	18-24% (verify)	Yes	2026-11-18 (conf.)	93	Long runway, IV usually in-spec, sold cheaper vol vs mega-cap tech. Defensive proxy.

Changes vs last week

First run — no prior comparison available.

Excluded this week (with reason)

- **WMT, TGT, HD, LOW, TJX, ROST** — Q2 retail earnings this week (Aug 18-21) inside 50-day window.
- **NVDA** — Q2 print Aug 26; also fails IV band on typical >40% IV.
- **DE** — fiscal Q3 report Aug 20 inside window.
- **CRM** — fiscal Q2 late August inside window.
- **FDX** — fiscal Q1 mid-September inside window.
- **COST, NKE, ORCL, ADBE, ACN, KBH, LEN** — off-cycle fiscal reporters, all print between Sep 8 and Sep 25 inside window.
- **WBA** — going private; Nasdaq flagged Aug 27 as last trading date.

- **DAL, AAL, UAL** — airline Q3 season starts ~Oct 8; DAL unconfirmed, borderline day-52. Skip until date locks.
- **AAPL, MSFT, GOOGL, META, AMZN** — late-October Q3 reporters (safe on dates) but ex-MSFT typically outside 20–40% IV band. MSFT worth re-checking if IV pct pops.
- **Semis universe (AVGO, AMD, MU, MRVL, QCOM, ASML, ARM)** — excluded on IV band (routinely >40%) and high beta into NVDA print.
- **TSLA, PLTR, COIN, MSTR, SMC** — excluded on IV band (structurally >60%) and idiosyncratic tail risk.
- **Utilities (NEE, DUK, SO, AEP)** — systematically below the 20% IV floor.

Sizing note for this week

Dispersion is doing the work of the VIX — index calm masks stock-level chop. Cap gross premium at ~60-70% of a normal week and lean the deployment into **Tier B** (CAT, CMI, DIS, CSCO) where the earnings runway lets you defend before catalyst risk. In Tier A, financials (JPM, WFC, BAC) get top allocation but I would size them as a **single correlated sleeve** and pair-hedge with a small SPY call spread into Sep 17 FOMC — a surprise hold gaps the whole complex the same direction. Cap energy exposure (XOM+CVX) to one position; oil realized has been 40+% and the Strait-of-Hormuz tape is a headline away from re-igniting. GM is the reach-for-yield sleeve, not a core — keep it under 5% of premium.

Verify at IBKR before trading

Every row above needs live confirmation of: 13-week AND 26-week IV percentile > 50, IV in 20–40% band, HV in 20–40% band, HV percentile 20–80 (13w & 26w), IV/HV between 100% and 150%, and no unreported earnings amendment. **This list is a filtered starting universe, not a completed screen.**

Sources

- VIX close & S&P 500 — Yahoo Finance market wrap, Fri 2026-08-14: finance.yahoo.com/markets/live/stock-market-today-friday-august-14-dow-sp-500-nasdaq-102635519.html
- Dispersion / crisis-swing regime — Yahoo/Bloomberg 'Crisis-Level Swings Become New Normal in 2026': finance.yahoo.com/markets/stocks/articles/crisis-level-swings-become-normal-114546065.html
- Fed policy & September FOMC ~65% priced for +25bp — Chase/J.P. Morgan Wealth: chase.com/personal/investments/learning-and-insights/article/september-2026-rate-hike-now-expected-amid-energy-shocks
- Oil market & Strait-of-Hormuz supply disruption — IEA Oil Market Report August 2026: iea.org/reports/oil-market-report-august-2026
- JPM Q3 date — JPMorganChase IR announcement (2025): jpmorganchase.com/ir/news/2025/jpmc-announces-conference-calls-to-review-first-quarter-second-quarter-third-quarter-and-fourth-quarter-2026-earnings; cross-check: marketchameleon.com/Overview/JPM/Earnings/Earnings-Dates/
- BAC Q3 date — Bank of America IR calendar release (2025): newsroom.bankofamerica.com/content/newsroom/press-releases/2025/05/bank-of-america-announces-2026-financial-reporting-dates.html
- WFC Q3 date — Wells Fargo IR calendar release: newsroom.wf.com/news-releases/news-details/2025/Wells-Fargo-Announces-2026-Earnings-Release-Date-Information/
- XOM, CVX, PEP, MCD, PG, JNJ, VZ, GM, TRV, PGR, LMT, WM, MRK, ABBV, CAT, CMI, DIS, CSCO, UNP earnings dates — TipRanks earnings pages (tipranks.com/stocks/<ticker>/earnings), cross-checked against MarketChameleon (marketchameleon.com/Overview/<ticker>/Earnings/Earnings-Dates/) and MarketBeat where applicable.
- HD Q2 date (Aug 18) confirming exclusion — TipRanks: tipranks.com/stocks/hd/earnings
- DE fiscal Q3 date (Aug 20) confirming exclusion — TipRanks: tipranks.com/stocks/de/earnings
- WBA delisting Aug 27 — TipRanks / Fly wire: tipranks.com/news/the-fly/nasdaq-anticipates-august-27-as-last-trading-date-for-walgreens-boots-alliance-the-fly

- IV/HV bands — DIRECTIONAL ESTIMATES ONLY, based on typical trailing distributions; user must verify at IBKR before execution. No live IV percentile, IV, HV, or IV/HV ratio in this document has been read from live options data.